HIS WELFARE STATE Women tie rakhi to CM Eknath Shinde after the launch of Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin scheme in Mumbai, Jun. 29

of Rs 1,500. The women can use this to buy clothes, toys, eatables and for the school fees of their children. Thus, this money will circulate in the economy." The move has ignited competition among rival parties. The Congress has pledged to raise the Ladki Bahin dole to Rs 2,000 per month if elected, while Shinde, seeking re-election, has promised to double it to Rs 3,000.

The election in Maharashtra is expected to be held in mid-November, by which time the women will get a total of five instalments. The government will also be able to meet its target of 25 million enrolment. The implementation is being closely monitored by a public welfare cell in the CM's office. Women and child development minister Aditi Tatkare says an estimated 25 million women will be eligible for the Ladki Bahin scheme. The first instalment of Rs 3,000 covering the payout for over 10 million for two months was given in mid-August at a cost of over Rs 3,000 crore. "This is an important step towards women's empowerment. This money will help them meet household expenses and boost their savings. The funds will also circulate in the economy and rejuvenate rural markets," she says. Officials state that the disbursement of the third instalment has begun.

These welfare initiatives underscore the government's strategy to strengthen its appeal among critical voter demographics. A senior Mahayuti leader claims that women are swayed more by emotion than ideology and are hence likely to stand by a government they feel delivers for them. The state has some 108 schemes for women, covering all aspects from the cradle to the grave, be it scholarships, funds for self-help groups or for marriage. Senior citizens are another major constituency that can be swayed by welfare initiatives. But journalist Hemant Desai argues that such schemes have not influenced the mandate in Maharashtra so far. "The people will take the performance of the government into account. The government is coming across as being desperate by floating such schemes," he says.

POLL-TIME BONANZA

Major welfare schemes that chiefly target the women, the senior citizens and the youth

Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana

Women aged between 21 and 60 will get Rs 1,500 per month subject to a cap of two women per household. Women from families with an annual income of less than Rs 2.50 lakh can apply

- **Expenditure:** ₹46,000 cr.
- **No. of beneficiaries:** 25 mn

Mukhyamantri Annapoorna Yojana

Three free annual LPG refills to those eligible for the Centre's Ujjwala and the state's Ladki Bahin schemes

- **Expenditure:** ₹829 cr.
- **No. of beneficiaries:** 5.2 mn households + Ladki Bahin recipients

Mukhyamantri Baliraja Mofat Vij Yojana

Free electricity to agriculture pumps of up to 7.5 horsepower capacity

- **Expenditure:** ₹14,761 cr.
- **No. of beneficiaries:** 4.4 mn

Magel Tyala Solar Power Pump

Farmers to get solar-powered pumps. It will see agricultural power grids being separated and solar-powered to provide uninterrupted electricity to farmers during day time

- **Expenditure:** ₹27,000 cr.
- **No. of beneficiaries:** 850,000

Free professional education for women

Girl students from the EWS, OBC and socially and economically backward categories pursuing diploma/ degree courses in engineering, architecture, pharmacy, medicine and agriculture to get 100 per cent fee waiver. Those with family income of less than Rs 8 lakh can apply

- **Expenditure:** ₹2,000 cr.
- **No. of beneficiaries:** 205,000

Mukhyamantri Yuva Karya Prashikshan Yojana

On-the-job training for youths in industrial and non-industrial establishments every year. A trainee will get a stipend of up to Rs 10,000 per month

- **Expenditure:** ₹10,000 cr.
- **No. of beneficiaries:** 1 mn

Mukhyamantri Teerth Darshan Yojana

Senior citizens with annual household income of Rs 2.50 lakh or less can visit pilgrimage centres in the state (66) and the country (73) through accredited tourist companies

- **Expenditure:** No outlay yet
- **No. of beneficiaries:** 36,000

Mukhyamantri Vayoshri Yojana

Senior citizens above 65 years and with an annual family income of under Rs 2 lakh will get aid up to Rs 3,000 to buy assisted living devices and physical aids

- **Expenditure:** ₹450 cr.
- **No. of beneficiaries:** 1.25-1.5 mn

THE FINANCIAL BURDEN

The all-round largesse has raised concerns about its impact on the state's finances. Ladki Bahin alone is expected to cost the exchequer Rs 46,000 crore, and the total financial burden of all schemes may exceed Rs 90,000 crore. Deputy chief minister and finance minister Ajit Pawar presented a Rs 6.12 lakh crore budget in June, with a fiscal deficit of Rs 1.10 lakh crore. This was followed by supplementary demands amounting to Rs 96,000 crore. However, Shinde claims that provisions have been made for these schemes. "The fiscal deficit is below the 3 per cent threshold mandated by the FRBM Act, 2003. The government is permitted to borrow up to 25 per cent of the GDP, with current levels at 17.5 per cent." But journalist and political analyst Santosh Pradhan cautions: "The fiscal deficit will rise above 3 per cent